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To test God

Introduction

The sign of the fleece proposed by Gideon to God for a confirmation of his calling (Judges 6:36-40) is one the most fascinating accounts of a human being asking God for a direct proof of Him. We read in the Bible that Gideon asks God for two signs using a wool fleece to confirm he was the one to be used by God to save Israel.

In the first test, Gideon said to God:

“If you will save Israel by my hand as you have promised- look, I will place a wool fleece on the threshing floor. If there is dew only on the fleece and all the ground is dry, then I will know that you will save Israel by my hand, as you said.” And that is what happened. Gideon rose early the next day; he squeezed the fleece and wrung out the dew- a bowlful of water. (Judges 6:36-38).

In the second test, Gideon said to God:

“Do not be angry with me. Let me make just one more request. Allow me one more test with the fleece, but this time make the fleece dry and let the ground be covered with dew.” That night God did so. Only the fleece was dry; all the ground was covered with dew. (Judges 6:39-40).

So, in order for Gideon to be completely sure of God’s plan for him, he proposed a test and the reverse of that test to God, and we read that both of them were successful. It is sensible to deduce that because God had a plan for Gideon, it would be enough for him to ask for only one of the tests, and no matter which one, it still would’ve been successful. Suppose he did just that, we would have a map of outcomes as illustrated in the Figure 1 below:

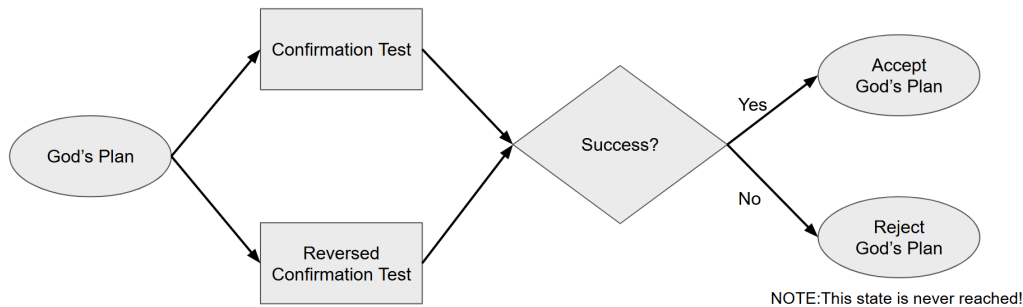


Figure 1: Gideon's acceptance map of God's plan if he only tested God once.

We can assert that if Gideon had only performed one of the tests, no matter which one, it would've been successful and therefore Gideon would go on with God's plan. In other words, both tests had the same probability of success.

During an email exchange with a friend of mine, he sent me the following email:

"Your question reminded me of an experience I had when I was younger. I was at the time studying to be prepared to apply for an engineering school. Some schools did ask for two years of preparation, and some only for one. At the end of the first year, I applied to a school which was (at the time) the third best school in the country. And it happened they selected me at the end of my first year of prep-school. I had a dilemma: Should I accept this offer, or continue the prep-school for another better school a year later ... I was walking back to my house from that prep-school and decided to ask God for an answer. I prayed and the verses which came to my mind were about Gideon (Judges 6). So I asked God saying that if the next three cars passing in front of me on the road were red it meant He was telling me to accept this school offer. If not, I would continue to study for another year in prep-school And it happened that indeed three red cars went by just then This could not have been a random action in my opinion, and I used the notion of randomness to ask God to act in showing me an answer Just an experience, I do not think we always should ask God that way, but it was what allowed me to be who I am in life now." (Note: Some parts were slightly modified to keep anonymous.)

And I replied saying:

“Right, you told me about that before, and I still think what would happen if you switched the meaning of the outcomes: three red cars mean God telling you NOT to accept the offer; would those three red cars still pass by, or at least one of them would be a different color?”

Although he did not answer the question, it was great to catch up with him I should say. But after that interaction, I thought about it more, and after some time I decided to set up an experiment (or simulation) that resembles that very scenario, in light of what happened to Gideon.

Hypothesis

In my friend's experience, let's assume that God's plan was indeed for him to accept the offer, in light of Gideon's story, two tests could have been conducted. Let's say that the first is the confirmation test and the second, the reversed confirmation test:

1. If three red cars pass by, then he accepts the offer. [*And three red cars actually pass by*].
2. If not three red cars pass by, then he accepts the offer. [*And not three red cars actually pass by*].

We hypothesise that both of the scenarios should result in similar probabilities because it is God's plan that he accepts the offer. Choosing one test or the other should not make a difference because that's what God's plan is for his life.

Experiment

We place two observers watching the cars that pass by on a road (only one way is considered for simplicity).

The first observer chooses the first test:

1. If three red cars pass by, then he accepts the offer.

While the second observer chooses the second:

2. If not three red cars pass by, then he accepts the offer.

The car colors selected for this experiment are: Red, Navy Blue, Grey, White and Yellow.

The two observers, denoted ob1 and ob2, are placed on the side of the road according to Figure 2 below:



Figure 2: Two observers (ob1 and ob2) on the side of the road ready to watch the cars driving by. The cars drive in the direction starting from the top-left corner, passing by ob1, and follow the trip till the lower-left corner, passing by ob2. The cars are emitted randomly. For simplicity, they are represented by the first letter of their respective color; so R for Red, N for Navy Blue, G for Grey, W for White and Y for Yellow. Below is Figure 3 illustrating the car flow:

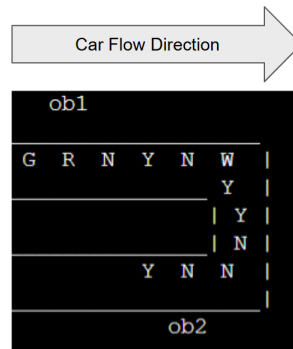


Figure 3: Both observers watching the cars passing by.

Results

After observing a million cars, ob1 has seen 8081 total groups of three red cars, which is 0.81% and ob2 has seen 991917 total groups of not three red cars, which is 99.19%. So, the first observer had a miniscule probability of only 0.81% to see three red cars, while the second observer had a very near absolute probability of 99.19% to see not three red cars.¹

¹ Source Code: <https://github.com/jaci-hub/totestgod>

Discussion

Had my friend conducted the second test (*If not three red cars pass by, then accept the offer*) instead of the first one (*If three red cars pass by, then accept the offer*), as he walked back to his house, would the three red cars he saw then still drive by?

Our experiment asserts with near absolute certainty that conducting one test or the other, does not yield similar probabilities of success. The first test is nearly impossible to succeed compared to its reverse, but it did anyway. One may argue that that is the very definition of a miracle from God, to put forth His plan for his life, another may simply argue that that is a mere coincidence. It boils down to believing or not believing.

Also, how do we create a test for God? Is there a step-by-step guide or rulebook, or does it just depend on our creativity and imagination? It is a given that we either expect an event with low probability of success to succeed, or with high probability of success to fail, but in order to be convinced, one could create a test that completely rules out coincidences. In this line of thought, my friend's test could be *to rotate the pyramid of Giza by 90 degrees clockwise*. Are there any test restrictions? Maybe my friend's test could be to ask God *to end a war in a region*. What about limits; how many tests are we allowed to ask? My friend's test could be a series of tests asking God *to end hunger, diseases, etc.* Is there a spectrum or scale of how "big" or "hard" a test is? Are there miracles more miraculous than others? My friend's test could be *to wake up the next morning with his hair dyed a different color, or to transform the Amazon forest into a desert, and the Sahara desert into a forest*. Is there a possibility of creating the wrong test and getting a false negative? What if my friend chose that forest-desert test and it was not successful despite it being God's plan for him to accept the offer?

Conclusion

We have examined my friend's experience where he asked for proof of God in real life and His plan for his life. We showed through a mathematical experiment that choosing one test over the other, results in completely different probabilities of success; unless it is God's plan, then they are just equally as likely to succeed.